Easter turning

Women in Turning: egg crate project live auction lot at the 2015 AAW Symposium

Easter is upon us and turning things specifically for this season is quite hard. If one wants to turn eggs, then one has to decide what to do with them. Well, I saw a lovely display of turned and decorated eggs at last year's AAW symposium. I think you will agree that this picture shows some wonderful work and a brilliant collaborative effort. In this issue, Stuart King takes a slightly different route and has a bit of fun with his egg creation: look on page 15.

Now onto something that always crops up, but can't be solved easily: the prices of tools and equipment. I am always amused, and at times amazed, when people say that something is not worth the money. Typically this is said after they have picked up an item, pored over it and then put it down again. It might be that the item is shoddily made and definitely not worth what is being asked for it. It could be that it is a well-made item and is worth the money as far as quality is concerned, but that person does not want to spend so much on buying it. They may not be able to pay that much, or they may feel that the item is not going to be used sufficiently to get their money's worth from it.

A while back we reproduced Issue 1 of *Woodturning* for people to see what the magazine looked like 25 years ago. I received numerous calls regarding the kit and tools featured in issue 1 and some comments about certain makes not being available any more. Many callers mentioned that tool prices 25 years ago were not very different from today and in some cases are now much cheaper.

Perception is a strange thing. I know that when I go to buy something, especially connected to my hobbies, I have to make a value call as to what I can spend and what I can get for the available monies I have or want to spend. I have to balance what I will do with the items I want/need and how often they will be used. If I use something every day and the top-of-the-range item does what I need, time in time out without fuss, even if it costs me £300 then it is likely money well spent. However, if I opted only to spend £150, the item may not do what I wanted it to do and might wear out more quickly. It would therefore be a false economy to select the cheaper tool. If the lower priced item did do what I needed from it and lasted even 60% of the use time of the more expensive one, then I would have gained overall. In this case, £300 has bought me two items that do the same job and I have got more time out of them. The big trouble is that people want the durability, action and capacity of professional items, but at hobby-rated tool prices. In most cases, there is a vast difference between the two, especially when it comes to quality of machinery, precision and also the motors used. I should know; I have made bad choices and regretted my decision to buy cheaply rather than make sure what I was buying really did what it said it could do. When tool prices differ by a few hundred pounds, then one really needs to find out the differences in quality. In real terms, we get far more for our money now than we have before.

So recalling advice given to me by a colleague in my apprentice days, we should try to buy wisely and buy once, which is often a case of buying quality not quantity.

Have fun,
Mark

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